

Word family: **classic / classics / classical / classically**

Base word: classic

Plural: classics

Related forms: classical, classically

Part of speech: adjective (形容詞) / noun (名詞)

Your sentence:

> “...it is one of those books that has become almost a modern **classic** in non-fiction.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **classic** is a noun meaning a **work that has become widely respected, influential, and likely to remain valued for a long time**.

The phrase **modern classic** means a relatively recent work that is already regarded as having unusually lasting importance or quality.

繁體中文： ** **受到廣泛肯定、具有持久價值和影響力，被視為某一類別中經典作品的書籍、電影、作品等**

中文翻譯：

> “...it has become almost a modern **classic** in non-fiction.”

「.....它幾乎已經成為非小說類作品中的一部現代**經典**。」

Here:

a modern classic = 雖然作品相對現代，但已被廣泛視為具有長久價值和代表性的經典作品

1. **classic = highly respected work with lasting value (作品) — 經典作品；名著**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: A book, film, piece of music, work of art, etc. that is widely admired and considered to have lasting importance or quality.

Practice 1 — Original

> “The book has become a modern **classic**.”

「這本書已成為一部現代**經典**。」

Practice 2

> “The novel is regarded as a **classic** of English literature.”

「這部小說被視為英國文學的**經典作品**。」

Practice 3

> “The film became a cult **classic**.”

「這部電影後來成為一部備受特定觀眾推崇的**經典作品**。」

classic = 經過時間或廣泛評價後，仍具有高度價值、代表性或影響力的作品

Common:

- * literary classic
- * modern classic
- * film classic
- * cult classic
- * children's classic

2. **classic** = outstanding/typical example of its kind (典型代表) — 經典的；典型的

As an adjective, **classic** can mean something is an excellent, highly characteristic, or easily recognized example of its type.

Practice 4

> “That is a **classic** example of poor communication.”

「那是一個溝通不良的**典型例子**。」

Practice 5

> “The building has a **classic** design.”

「這棟建築採用了**經典 / 典型的**設計。」

classic = 非常能代表某一類型特徵，或被公認為該類型中的代表性例子

Common:

- * classic example
- * classic case
- * classic mistake
- * classic design
- * classic style

This is a major adjective meaning.

3. **classic = traditional and enduring in style (風格) — 經典的 ; 傳統而不易過時的**

Classic can describe clothes, design, furniture, colours, etc. whose style is traditional, elegant, and likely to remain attractive rather than quickly going out of fashion.

Practice 6

> “She wore a **classic** black dress.”

「她穿了一條**經典、耐看的**黑色連身裙。」

Practice 7

> “The room combines modern furniture with **classic** details.”

「房間把現代家具和**經典傳統**細節結合起來。」

classic = 風格傳統、耐看、不容易過時，長期被視為有品味或代表性的

For strict counting, I would keep this as a useful branch of Meaning 2:

> representative/established style

but show it explicitly because it is extremely common.

4. **classic = famous or memorable example of behaviour/situation (情況) — 經典的 ; 老套而典型的**

In informal speech, **classic** can describe a behaviour, mistake, excuse, situation, etc. that is very characteristic or predictably typical.

Practice 8

> “That was a **classic** mistake.”

「那是一個很**典型 / 經典的**錯誤。」

Practice 9

> “It was a **classic** case of misunderstanding.”

「那是一宗很**典型的**誤會案例。」

classic = 某種情況極具代表性，幾乎是一看就知道屬於那一類的

This belongs semantically to Meaning 2 rather than requiring another core sense.

5. **a classic** = exceptionally memorable thing/event (口語) — 經典之作；非常精彩 / 難忘的東西

As a noun in informal English, **a classic** can refer to something unusually funny, memorable, excellent, or characteristic.

Practice 10

> “That comment was an absolute **classic**.”

「那句話真是**經典**。」

Practice 11

> “The match was a **classic**.”

「那場比賽堪稱**經典之戰**。」

a classic = 非常精彩、難忘或具有代表性的事情 / 作品

This develops directly from the “outstanding example” meaning and does not need a separate top-level category.

6. **classic** = established/basic version of something (產品 / 款式) — 經典款；原味 / 基本款

In product naming and everyday commercial language, **classic** can describe the established, standard, original, or traditional version.

Practice 12

> “I ordered the **classic** burger.”

「我點了**經典款 / 基本款**漢堡。」

Practice 13

> “The company brought back its **classic** design.”

「公司重新推出它的**經典設計**。」

classic = 某產品、菜式或款式最具代表性、最傳統或長期存在的版本

For core counting, I would merge this with Meaning 3 rather than treat product context as a new meaning.

The Golden Manual specifically warns against splitting senses merely because the following noun or commercial context changes when the same underlying semantic idea still applies.

Related form: **classical**

Classical is related to **classic**, but its modern meanings have become partly independent.

It should **not** simply be treated as the adjective form of every meaning of **classic**.

classical = relating to ancient Greek/Roman civilization (古典時代) — 古典的

Practice 14

> “She studied **classical** history.”

「她研究**古典時代**的歷史。」

Practice 15

> “The building was influenced by **classical** architecture.”

「這座建築受到**古典建築**影響。」

classical = 與古希臘、古羅馬文化、藝術、語言或其傳統有關的

classical = traditional established form of an art/subject (藝術 / 學科) — 古典的；傳統體系

的**

Practice 16

> “He listens to **classical** music.”

「他聽**古典音樂**。」

Practice 17

> “She trained in **classical** ballet.”

「她接受過**古典芭蕾**訓練。」

****classical** = 屬於某種歷史悠久、規範完整、正式傳統的藝術或學術形式**

Common:

- * classical music
- * classical ballet
- * classical literature
- * classical studies

**classical = established older scientific model (科學) — 經典的 ; 古典的**

In some academic fields, ****classical**** refers to an older or foundational theoretical framework contrasted with newer theories.

Examples:

- * classical physics
- * classical mechanics
- * classical economics

Practice 18

> “The course begins with ****classical mechanics****.”

「這門課先從**經典力學**開始。」

This is an established specialist use.

Related form: **classically**

Practice 19

> “The building is **classically** proportioned.”

「這座建築具有**古典式的**比例。」

Practice 20

> “She is **classically** trained.”

「她接受過**正統古典訓練**。」

classically = 以古典、傳統正式體系或古典風格的方式

Important distinction: **classic vs classical**

This is the most important learner distinction.

classic

usually means:

- * highly respected and enduring;
- * typical/representative;
- * traditional and timeless in style.

- > classic novel
- > classic example
- > classic design

classical

usually means:

- * ancient Greek/Roman;
- * traditional formal artistic system;
- * established historical scientific framework.

- > classical music
- > classical architecture
- > classical mechanics

So:

> **classic music** ❌ normally

> **classical music** ✅

But:

> **a classic song** ✅

means a song regarded as enduringly excellent.

Important distinction: **classic vs traditional**

traditional

means based on long-established customs or practices.

classic

often adds:

- * high recognition;
- * representativeness;
- * enduring appeal.

Something can be traditional without being regarded as a classic.

Important distinction: **classic vs iconic**

classic

emphasizes lasting quality, recognition, or representativeness.

iconic

emphasizes being widely recognized as a powerful symbol of a person, period, brand, culture, etc.

> classic novel

> iconic photograph

There is overlap, but the emphasis differs.

Important distinction: **classic vs famous**

famous

simply means widely known.

classic

suggests recognized lasting value or exemplary status.

A book can be famous without becoming a classic.

That distinction matters directly in your passage:

> Sapiens is described not merely as well-known, but as something approaching **classic status**.

Important distinction: **classic vs masterpiece**

masterpiece

means a work regarded as exceptionally skilful or outstanding.

classic

emphasizes lasting recognition and representative importance.

A masterpiece may become a classic, but the concepts are not identical.

Countability note

As a noun, **classic** is countable:

> a classic

> several classics

Examples:

> a literary classic

> the classics of world literature

The classics can also refer collectively to famous canonical works, or in academic contexts to the study of ancient Greek and Roman civilization.

That academic use is more naturally associated with **Classics** as a field and should be treated as a lexicalized/domain extension rather than another ordinary meaning of **classic**.

Useful expression: **a modern classic — 現代經典**

Practice 21

> “The film is now considered a modern **classic**.”

「這部電影現在被視為一部**現代經典**。」

Practice 22

> “Many readers regard the novel as a modern **classic**.”

「很多讀者把這本小說視為**現代經典作品**。」

modern classic = 年代相對較近，但已被廣泛認為具有長久價值和代表性的作品

This is exactly the pattern in your passage.

Useful expression: **classic example/case — 典型例子 / 案例**

Practice 23

> “This is a **classic example** of how small errors can grow.”

「這是一個小錯誤如何逐步擴大的**典型例子**。」

This belongs to the representative-example sense.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

* **classic**

* **classics**
* **classical**
* **classically**

The important point is that **classical** has developed several established meanings of its own and should not be mechanically defined as simply “related to classic.”

The Golden Manual requires the family sweep to include lexical relatives generously while accurately separating forms that have developed independent modern functions.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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classic — enduring work	長期受到廣泛肯定、具有持久價值和代表性的作品；經典
classic — typical example	非常能代表某一類型特徵的典型例子 / 情況
classic — timeless style	傳統、耐看、不容易過時，長期被視為有代表性的
a classic — memorable/outstanding thing	非常精彩、難忘或具有代表性的事物；與 enduring/example 義相關
classic — standard/traditional version	某產品、設計或款式的傳統、基本或最具代表性版本
classical — Greek/Roman	與古希臘、古羅馬文明及其傳統有關的
classical — art/music	屬於歷史悠久、正式而規範的傳統藝術形式
classical — scientific/academic	屬於某領域較早、基礎或傳統理論體系的
classically	以古典 / 正統傳統體系或風格的方式

For your original sentence

> “...it is one of those books that has become almost a modern **classic** in non-fiction.”

The exact meaning is:

classic = 一部已受到廣泛認可、具有代表性和長期價值的作品

So:

> **a modern classic in non-fiction**

= **非小說類作品中的一部現代經典**

The phrase does more than say the book is **popular** or **famous**. It suggests the book has gained a reputation for **lasting significance and influence**.

For your database, I would count **3 genuinely useful core meanings** for **classic**:

1. **noun** — an enduring, widely respected work
2. **adjective** — highly typical or representative of its kind
3. **adjective** — traditional, timeless, or established in style/form

I would merge **classic product/design/style** into #3, merge **classic mistake/case/example** into #2, and keep **classical / classically** as closely related but partly independent family extensions rather than inflate the base-word count.